

Suffering With

The True Definition of Compassion, and What the Bible Really Says About Suicide and Euthanasia

A Word Before Anything Else

If you are reading this in pain, whether your own or the pain of watching someone you love suffer, this paper is for you, not against you. Nothing in these pages is written to condemn the desperate, to shame the grieving, or to lecture the dying. It is written because a very old word is being redefined in our lifetime, and the people most affected by the redefinition are the people with the least power to argue about it. That word is compassion.

And one thing should be said plainly at the outset, before any argument is made: if you are struggling under the weight of your own life right now, the conclusion of everything that follows is simple. You are not a burden to be relieved. You are a person to be accompanied. Talk to someone, a doctor, a pastor, a friend, a crisis line. The oldest rescue line in Christian history is only six words long, and it appears later in this paper: "Do not harm yourself; we are all here."

What the Word Actually Means

Compassion is built from two Latin words: com, meaning "with," and pati, meaning "to suffer." Compassion means, literally, to suffer with. Not to observe suffering from a distance. Not to manage it, and not to end it by ending the sufferer. To climb down into it beside the person and stay.

Keep that definition in hand, because two very different projects now compete for the word. One says: your suffering is unbearable, so we will bear it with you. The other says: your suffering is unbearable, so we will help you stop existing. Both call themselves compassion. Only one of them matches the word.

What the Bible Actually Records

Start with a fact that surprises most people, including many churchgoers: there is no verse in the Bible that says "suicide is a sin" in those words. The Bible records six suicides: a wounded warlord named Abimelech who asked his armor-bearer to finish him (Judges 9), King Saul and his armor-bearer falling on their swords after a lost battle (1 Samuel 31), a betrayed royal advisor named Ahithophel (2 Samuel 17), a defeated usurper named Zimri (1

Kings 16), and Judas, the man who betrayed Jesus (Matthew 27). In every case, the text reports the death without attaching a sermon to it. Scripture treats these deaths as tragedies inside larger tragedies, not as occasions for editorializing.

This matters because folk religion has taught, for centuries, something the Bible never says: that suicide is unforgivable and automatically damns a person. That teaching is not in Scripture. The only sin Jesus ever called unforgivable is something else entirely (a settled, willful calling of God's goodness evil, Mark 3:28-29), and it has nothing to do with dying in despair. Even the Roman Catholic Church, whose medieval practice was harshest on this point, has formally repudiated that harshness: its current catechism states that grave anguish and psychological suffering can diminish a person's responsibility, and that "we should not despair of the eternal salvation of persons who have taken their own lives." If you have lost someone this way, hear this clearly: the Bible nowhere teaches that their story ended outside the reach of God's mercy.

So the Bible's position is not built on a single prohibition verse. It is built on something deeper, and to see it, you have to watch how God actually treats people who want to die.

The Prayer God Never Punishes

Here is the second surprise: the Bible is full of faithful people telling God, to his face, that they want to die. And God never once punishes them for saying it.

Job, the Bible's great case study in unbearable suffering, a man who lost his children, his wealth, and his health in a single season, curses the day of his own birth and begs for death across entire chapters: "Why did I not die at birth?... I loathe my life" (Job 3:11, 10:1). His own wife proposes the exit: "Curse God and die" (Job 2:9). Job refuses it, keeps talking to God with brutal honesty instead, and at the end of the book, God's verdict on Job is that he "spoke of me what is right" (Job 42:7). The man who screamed his death-wish at heaven is the one God commends.

Moses, exhausted by leadership, prays: "If you will treat me like this, kill me at once" (Numbers 11:15). The prophet Jeremiah curses the day he was born (Jeremiah 20:14-18). Jonah asks God to take his life, twice (Jonah 4:3, 8). None of them is struck down or scolded for the wish.

And then there is Elijah, and his story may be the most important passage on this subject in the entire Bible. Elijah was a prophet at the peak of his career, fresh off his greatest public victory, when a death threat broke something in him. He fled alone into the desert, sat down under a broom tree, and prayed: "It is enough; now, O LORD, take away my life" (1 Kings 19:4). A burned-out man, alone, asking God for death.

Now watch God's response, because it is not what religion has trained you to expect. No rebuke. No sermon. No demand for gratitude or perspective. An angel touches him and

says, "Arise and eat." There is bread and water. Elijah eats and goes back to sleep. The angel comes a second time: "Arise and eat, for the journey is too great for you." More food. More rest. Only after the meals and the sleep does God ask him a gentle question, listen to his despair at length, let him say the bleakest thing twice, and then give him a new assignment and a companion so he will not be alone (1 Kings 19:5-18).

God's answer to a man praying for death was a meal, a nap, another meal, another nap, a listening ear, a purpose, and a friend. That is the divine protocol for despair, recorded in detail three thousand years ago, and it is worth noticing that it looks exactly like what modern crisis care has independently discovered: address the body, restore rest, listen without judgment, rebuild purpose and connection. The Bible's answer to "I want to die" has never been condemnation. It has been bread, sleep, and presence.

Midnight in the Philippi Jail

The one direct suicide intervention in the Bible takes ten seconds and contains the whole Christian position.

The apostle Paul and his companion Silas are in prison in the Greek city of Philippi, beaten and in chains. At midnight an earthquake breaks the prison open. The jailer wakes, sees the doors open, and, knowing Roman law will hold him responsible with his life for escaped prisoners, draws his sword to kill himself. And Paul, from inside the dark, shouts:

"Do not harm yourself, for we are all here." (Acts 16:28)

Look at what that sentence is made of. Not "stop, it's a sin." Not an argument at all. A rescue built entirely on presence: we are all here. You are not alone in the dark, your catastrophe is not what you think it is, and there are people in this room with you. The jailer called for lights, fell down trembling, and asked, that same hour, the most famous question in the book of Acts: "What must I do to be saved?" The night that began with his sword against his own body ended with his whole household at a table, "rejoicing" (Acts 16:34).

Paul knew the pull of death from the inside, and said so in writing. Sitting in another prison, he weighed it openly: "My desire is to depart and be with Christ, for that is far better. But to remain in the flesh is more necessary on your account" (Philippians 1:23-24). He does not pretend the longing to be done with this life is alien or shameful. He outranks it with one thing: other people still need him. That is the Bible's honest math about staying: not that life is painless, but that your presence is load-bearing in more lives than you know.

What Jesus Said, and What He Was Like

Jesus never addressed suicide directly. But he addressed, constantly, the condition underneath it, and his recorded manner with crushed people is the evidence that matters most.

His open invitation was aimed precisely at the exhausted: "Come to me, all who labor and are heavy laden, and I will give you rest" (Matthew 11:28). The ancient prophecy he claimed as his own job description says: "A bruised reed he will not break, and a smoldering wick he will not quench" (Matthew 12:20). A bruised reed is a stalk already bent and damaged, one touch from snapping; a smoldering wick is a flame down to its last thread of smoke. The description of the Messiah is that he handles exactly such people, the nearly broken and the nearly extinguished, without finishing them off. Whatever else is true, a person at the end of their strength is in the one demographic Jesus explicitly promised to be gentle with.

One distinction his followers drew from the beginning: Jesus's own death was not self-destruction but self-sacrifice. "No one takes my life from me; I lay it down of my own accord" (John 10:18), and "Greater love has no one than this, that someone lay down his life for his friends" (John 15:13). The soldier who falls on a grenade, the mother who takes the bullet, the martyr who will not renounce, these deaths are for others, and the tradition has always honored them as a separate category from despair. The difference is direction: sacrificial death spends a life on other people; suicide is despair convincing a person that other people would be better off. The first is true. The second, as anyone who has stood at such a funeral knows, never is.

Why Your Life Is Not Yours to End

So if the Bible's case is not one prohibition verse, what is it? It is a claim about ownership, and it is stated in, of all things, the language of the marketplace.

"You are not your own, for you were bought with a price" (1 Corinthians 6:19-20). The Greek verb there, *agorazo*, is the ordinary word for purchasing something at market. The New Testament's writers, working in the commercial Greek of their day, described what happened at the cross as a transaction: a life was paid for yours. In the Bible's accounting, every human life is doubly claimed, once by creation ("in the image of God he created them," Genesis 1:27) and once by redemption, purchased at the highest price ever paid. The boundary of a life belongs to its owner: "My times are in your hand," the psalmist prays (Psalm 31:15), and God says of himself, "I kill and I make alive" (Deuteronomy 32:39). The commandment "You shall not murder" (Exodus 20:13) protects that boundary, and the church's oldest teachers argued it protects each person from every hand, including their own.

To a reader who has never opened a Bible, that may sound like a limitation. Sit with it a moment and you may hear what it actually is: a valuation. A thing may only not be discarded if it is worth too much to discard. The claim "your life is not yours to end" is, underneath, the claim "your life is worth more than you currently believe, and someone with better information than your despair has already paid full price to prove it."

The One Story About Mercy Killing

The Bible contains exactly one narrative about ending a dying man's life at his own request, and its verdict is unmistakable.

King Saul, mortally wounded on Mount Gilboa with the enemy closing in, asks his armor-bearer to finish him. The armor-bearer refuses; he "would not, for he feared greatly" (1 Samuel 31:4). Days later, a young Amalekite arrives at David's camp claiming that he found Saul dying, and that Saul begged him, "Stand beside me and kill me, for anguish has seized me," and that he did it, "because I was sure that he could not live after he had fallen" (2 Samuel 1:9-10). Notice his reasoning: the man was suffering, the man asked, the man was dying anyway. It is, word for word, the modern euthanasia argument, three thousand years early. The Amalekite expects a reward. David has him executed for killing "the LORD's anointed," treating the compassionate finishing of a dying man, at that man's own request, as killing (2 Samuel 1:14-16).

That is the biblical datum, and the entire Jewish and Christian tradition built on it: the deliberate act of ending a life, even a dying life, even a suffering life, even a requesting life, is not ours to perform.

The Line the Tradition Actually Drew

Here is where an honest account must be careful, because the tradition's teaching is more humane than its critics assume, and more humane than some of its defenders present it.

The line Scripture and the historic churches drew is not "terminal versus not terminal." It is hastening death versus ceasing to obstruct it. Those are different acts, and the difference carries everything. "For everything there is a season... a time to be born, and a time to die," says Ecclesiastes 3:1-2, without embarrassment. When the time to die genuinely comes, there has never been a biblical duty to fight it to the last machine. A dying person who declines another round of futile treatment is not committing suicide. Accepting full pain relief, even medication that may incidentally shorten a dying process, is not killing; it is comfort, and the tradition has explicitly blessed it. Going home from the hospital to die in your own bed, surrounded by your people, prayed over and held, is not surrender to be ashamed of. It is a death the Bible would recognize: "Then Jacob... drew up his feet into the bed and breathed his last and was gathered to his people" (Genesis 49:33), with his family around him and his blessings given.

So to the person facing a terminal road, or walking it beside someone: the Christian tradition does not ask you to prolong dying. It asks you not to kill. Between those two lies the entire, honorable field of hospice and palliative care, which was, not incidentally, invented by Christians (the modern hospice movement began with Dame Cicely Saunders, a devout believer, whose founding principle was: "You matter because you are you, and you matter to

the last moment of your life"). The alternative to a needle was never "suffer alone with no options." The alternative is a whole medical and human discipline dedicated to comfort, dignity, and presence at the end, and it works. Where it is funded and offered, requests to die drop.

What Is Happening Now: Two Countries as a Case Study

This is not an abstract debate, because two Western nations have now run the experiment, and their trajectories are a matter of public record.

The Netherlands legalized euthanasia in 2002, for unbearable suffering with no prospect of improvement, under what were described as strict safeguards. Two decades later, eligibility has extended in practice to psychiatric suffering, to dementia patients by advance directive, and to elderly couples choosing to die together, so-called duo-euthanasia, dozens of pairs a year, often one dying spouse and one healthy spouse who cannot face life alone. Dutch parliament has repeatedly debated a further step: a "completed life" provision for elderly people who are not sick at all, merely finished. Every one of these was, at legalization, dismissed as an alarmist fantasy.

Canada legalized medical assistance in dying in 2016, restricted to those whose natural death was "reasonably foreseeable." In 2021 that requirement was removed, opening eligibility to people who are not dying. Assisted death now accounts for roughly one in twenty deaths in Canada, among the highest rates on earth for a program a decade old, and journalists have documented cases of Canadians seeking it in connection with poverty, inadequate housing, and lack of disability support, suffering rooted not in disease but in abandonment. A further expansion, eligibility for people whose sole underlying condition is mental illness, was scheduled, delayed under protest, and delayed again; in 2025 a United Nations disability-rights committee formally called on Canada to reverse course, and in June 2026 a special parliamentary committee recommended pausing the mental-illness expansion indefinitely, after more than ninety disability and mental-health organizations opposed it. Their central argument was not religious at all: it was that no one can reliably distinguish a rational request to die from suicidality itself, the very condition medicine exists to treat. As of this writing, the expansion date of March 2027 still stands in law while the government considers its response.

Notice the direction of drift. In both countries, a program introduced for the imminently dying migrated, within a generation, toward the disabled, the mentally ill, the poor, and the lonely. And notice one more thing, quietly, because it explains the drift better than any philosophy: the economics run one way. A lethal dose costs a health system a few hundred dollars. Years of psychiatric care, disability support, or palliative care cost hundreds of thousands. When death is on the menu of a strained system, the incentive gradient points at the most expensive patients, who are always the most vulnerable people, and vulnerable

people can feel a gradient. More than one Canadian has reported being offered death by the system without asking. That is not a slippery-slope prediction. It is last year's news.

The Oldest Sales Pitch in the World

Readers who know the Bible's first pages will recognize the shape of all this, and readers who do not deserve to have it shown to them, because it is the oldest recorded sales pitch in human literature.

In the Bible's opening story, a serpent, which the book's last pages identify as the great deceiver himself (Revelation 12:9: "that ancient serpent, who is called the devil and Satan, the deceiver of the whole world"), sells the first humans a product. The product is death. The packaging is benefit: "You will not surely die... your eyes will be opened, and you will be like God" (Genesis 3:4-5). Death, marketed as enlightenment, as autonomy, as the sophisticated choice. It is the only product he has ever had, and the packaging is the only thing he has ever updated. Jesus's one-sentence biography of him: "He was a murderer from the beginning... he is a liar and the father of lies" (John 8:44). A murderer whose method is marketing.

So when death is offered today in the vocabulary of dignity, autonomy, and compassionate healthcare, a Bible reader is entitled to check the label against the oldest file in the archive. And the Bible supplies one more test, from its final book. Revelation 18 describes the fall of "Babylon," the Bible's code name for every civilization organized around wealth and power, by reading out its cargo manifest: gold, jewels, fabrics, spices, livestock, and then, deliberately last on the list, "slaves, that is, human souls" (Revelation 18:13). The verdict on the great economy is delivered by its own inventory: at the bottom of the glittering pyramid, human beings priced as cargo. Any system, in any century, that ends by pricing human lives, and finds the vulnerable ones cheapest to conclude, has been audited before.

The Bible's test of a society was never how it treats its strong. "Religion that is pure and undefiled before God the Father is this: to visit orphans and widows in their affliction" (James 1:27). The measure is taken at the bedside of the weakest, and a compassion that resolves the suffering of the poor, the disabled, and the despairing by removing them fails the audit by definition.

The Widow Under the Broom Tree

One more thing must be said, because it is the human center of the whole question.

Ask anyone who has walked closely with a newly widowed person, and they will tell you about a season, sometimes a long one, when the surviving spouse says, in complete sincerity, "I just want to be with him." It is one of the most common experiences of deep grief, and it is real, and it deserves to be honored, not corrected. And then ask them about

the same person three or four years later: the slow return of appetite, the first laugh that surprised her, the friendships, the routines, the causes, the grandchildren, the hobby she never expected, a life that is not the old life and is nevertheless a life, still missing him, no longer wishing to follow him early. The wish of the trough and the wish of the recovered years are both hers. Which one is truer?

Everything hinges on that question, because a euthanasia regime, by design, honors the trough's wish and forecloses the other one forever. It arrives with paperwork at the exact moment when the person is least themselves, ratifies the darkest hour as the final word, and guarantees that the woman with the friends and the hobbies and the surprising laugh will never exist. The Dutch duo-euthanasia bed is that broom tree with a different ending: no angel, no bread, no second nap, no journey ahead. Scripture's whole counter-testimony, Job restored, Elijah re-commissioned, the jailer at his midnight table, is that the broom tree is a chapter, not the book, and that the divine protocol for the person under it is food, rest, presence, purpose, and time.

What Compassion Actually Does

So, gathered into one place, here is what the Bible really says.

It says the desire to die is speakable, that the faithful have prayed it aloud for three thousand years, and that God's recorded response to it is nourishment and presence, never punishment. It says no verse damns the despairing, and the folk teaching that suicide is unforgivable is a human invention the church itself has renounced. It says your life is not disposable because it is not unowned: created in God's image, and purchased at the highest price ever paid, which is not a restriction but an appraisal. It says the deliberate ending of a life, even a dying and requesting life, is not ours to perform, and it says with equal force that no one is obligated to obstruct a death whose time has come, that comfort, presence, and letting go are fully blessed. It says a society is measured at the bedside of its weakest, and that death sold as benefit is the oldest counterfeit on record. And it says, in its final vision, what the actual answer to suffering is, and notice carefully what gets eliminated in it:

"He will wipe away every tear from their eyes, and death shall be no more, neither shall there be mourning, nor crying, nor pain anymore, for the former things have passed away."
(Revelation 21:4)

That verse is the entire disagreement in one sentence. God's announced solution to suffering is the death of death, the mourning, the crying, and the pain, and the wiping of the sufferer's tears by hand. The modern solution eliminates the sufferer and calls it the same thing. One ends the pain. The other ends the person. Only one of these can be called compassion, because only one of them stays in the room.

Which returns us, at the end, to the six words shouted from the dark of a Greek jail at a man

with a sword in his hand, the shortest and most complete statement of the whole ethic, and the sentence every human being in the trough is owed by the people around them, and by any society that still deserves the word compassionate:

"Do not harm yourself. We are all here."